

Religious Authority as Epistemic Architecture

Pluralism, Correction, and the Distribution of Religious Knowledge

Anthony Paterson / Instance001

Fractal Media Infrastructure

Conceptual companion draft - v0.3 - 27 August 2026

This paper is designed as a focused philosophical companion to *Architectural Legacies: A Structural Comparison of Polytheistic and Monotheistic Systems and Their Continuing Influence on Modern Institutions*. The earlier paper works at the macro level, comparing broad organizational patterns. The present paper narrows the lens to one mechanism: how religious systems distribute epistemic authority, manage disagreement, and preserve the capacity for correction. It is written to stand independently and should not require the companion paper to be read first.

Abstract

Philosophical discussion of religious disagreement commonly asks what a rational individual should believe after encountering sincere, apparently competent disagreement. This paper shifts the unit of analysis one level outward. Before disagreement reaches an individual, religious communities already possess an **epistemic architecture**: a patterned distribution of authority across scriptures, traditions, institutions, specialists, practices, local communities, and individual judgement. That architecture affects which disagreements become visible, whose testimony receives weight, how interpretations are stabilized, how error propagates, and whether correction remains possible.

The paper distinguishes two levels that are often blurred together. **Sacred sovereignty** concerns where ultimate divine authority is claimed to reside; **epistemic distribution** concerns how human communities interpret, transmit, contest, and apply that authority. For the present analysis, a monotheistic architecture is one in which legitimate sacred authority ultimately terminates in a single divine source, however many subordinate persons, messengers, intermediaries, or institutions appear below it. A polytheistic architecture permits multiple divine authorities with irreducible standing, even where one deity enjoys primacy or kingship. This distinction prevents simple head-counting: plurality inside a hierarchy is not the same thing as plurality at its apex.

At the downstream epistemic level, the paper develops two ideal-type mechanisms: **concentrated epistemic authority** and **distributed epistemic authority**. Concentration can reduce coordination costs, preserve continuity, and support common reference points, but it can also amplify authoritative error and make correction dependent on a small number of gatekeeping nodes. Distribution can preserve multiple interpretive sites, local knowledge, and independent routes of correction, but it can also increase fragmentation, unresolved conflict, and the difficulty of maintaining shared identity. The two axes are independent enough to matter: a monotheistic tradition may distribute interpretation widely, while a polytheistic tradition may centralize important human institutions.

The central argument is that a durable religious epistemic system requires more than either unity or plurality alone. It requires **bounded pluralism**: enough shared structure to sustain a recognizable tradition, combined with enough independent interpretive capacity to preserve disagreement, expose error, and revise

inherited judgements without dissolving continuity. The claim is architectural rather than theological. It does not assess the truth of religious beliefs or the sincerity of adherents. It asks how the organization of epistemic authority changes the consequences of disagreement, error, and correction within communities whose beliefs are transmitted socially across time.

Keywords: philosophy of religion; religious epistemology; epistemic authority; religious disagreement; social epistemology; testimony; tradition; pluralism; institutional epistemology

1. Introduction: disagreement has an architecture

Religious disagreement is usually presented as a problem for believers. A person holds a religious belief, discovers that another apparently intelligent and sincere person disagrees, and must decide what epistemic significance to assign to that disagreement. Contemporary work asks whether the believer should reduce confidence, suspend judgement, remain steadfast, distinguish peers from non-peers, or appeal to evidence not shared by the disputant (Christensen 2007; Feldman 2007; Benton and Kvanvig 2021; Pittard 2021).

Those are important questions. They are not, however, the whole problem.

By the time two individuals confront one another as religious disagreeers, a great deal of epistemic work has already occurred. Each person has inherited some combination of texts, traditions, teachers, institutions, practices, commentaries, testimonies, interpretive habits, communal memories, and expectations about who is entitled to speak with authority. Some disagreements were preserved and taught; others disappeared. Some sources became canonical; others became marginal. Some interpretations acquired institutional standing; others survived only locally or not at all. Some forms of testimony were treated as credible by default; others were filtered through suspicion. The individual disagreement therefore takes place inside an already structured epistemic environment.

This paper calls that environment an **epistemic architecture**.

The term does not imply that religions are engineered in the manner of machines, nor that their histories can be reduced to formal diagrams. It is a functional abstraction. An epistemic architecture is the relatively durable pattern by which a community distributes the work of producing, preserving, interpreting, transmitting, contesting, and revising beliefs. It includes at least five questions:

1. **Where may epistemic authority reside?**
2. **How much weight is assigned to different authorities?**
3. **How can authorities be challenged or corrected?**
4. **How are disagreements preserved, resolved, or excluded?**
5. **How does the community maintain continuity while interpretation changes?**

These questions are familiar in religious life, but they are often treated separately: as questions about scripture, tradition, testimony, expertise, councils, individual judgement, revelation, or disagreement. Social epistemology provides reason to study them together. Zagzebski's work on epistemic authority explicitly treats authority as a problem of trust, testimony, autonomy, and community rather than merely individual evidence assessment (Zagzebski 2012). More recent work in the epistemology of theology similarly recognizes the importance of tradition, testimony, authority, and communal practices to religious knowledge (Wynn 2017).

Kojonen's application of social epistemology to *sola scriptura* illustrates how different models of authority can generate different relations between deference and correction even within one religious family (Kojonen 2024).

The present argument extends this line of thought. It proposes that the **distribution** of epistemic authority is itself philosophically significant. A religious tradition may be more or less centralized in its interpretive authority, more or less tolerant of parallel authorities, more or less able to preserve unresolved disagreement, and more or less dependent on a narrow set of nodes for correction. These structural differences change the cost of error and the conditions under which revision is possible.

The central thesis is deliberately modest:

The epistemic quality of a religious tradition cannot be assessed only by asking whether its members possess good reasons. We must also ask how the tradition distributes authority, because authority structure changes how evidence, testimony, disagreement, and error travel through the community.

This does not establish which religious beliefs are true. Nor does it imply that decentralization is epistemically superior to centralization. Both solve real problems and create real risks. The philosophical task is to understand the trade-off.

2. From individual disagreement to institutional epistemology

The epistemology of disagreement often begins with a relatively clean encounter between agents. A and B have considered some proposition (p), each regards the other as competent, and they discover that they disagree. The philosophical question concerns what A should now believe given B's dissent. The literature then becomes concerned with peerhood, higher-order evidence, conciliation, steadfastness, private evidence, and the possibility that religious disagreement has distinctive features (Benton 2021; Feldman 2007; Pittard 2021).

Religious communities complicate this picture in two ways.

First, religious belief is heavily dependent on **social transmission**. Even a believer who emphasizes personal experience usually acquires the vocabulary, narratives, categories, interpretive possibilities, and background assumptions through which that experience is understood from other people. Scripture itself is encountered through practices of preservation, translation, selection, teaching, and interpretation. Tradition is not merely a pile of old propositions but an inherited context in which present judgement occurs. Wynn, for example, describes tradition as requiring creative, case-specific judgement about what belongs to an original revelatory deposit and what reflects culturally local assumptions (Wynn 2017). The act of preserving a tradition therefore already contains interpretive work.

Second, religious communities do not merely transmit information; they assign **unequal epistemic roles**. A priest, theologian, elder, jurist, scholar, mystic, parent, local teacher, canonical author, institutional body, or ordinary believer may each have different standing. Authority can be formal or informal, local or universal, defeasible or nearly final. It may derive from office, expertise, lineage, sanctity, tradition, communal recognition, claimed revelation, or some combination of these.

This means that the question "How should I respond to disagreement?" is downstream from another question:

Who was allowed to become an epistemically significant disagreeer in the first place?

A tradition that centralizes doctrinal authority may prevent some disagreements from reaching ordinary members as live options. A tradition with many semi-independent interpretive centres may expose members to a greater range of competing views. A tradition may preserve dissenting arguments in its educational canon, or it may record only the resolution. It may treat certain sources as final, as presumptively authoritative, or merely as advisory. These choices influence the apparent evidential landscape available to the believer.

This is not necessarily manipulative. All knowledge systems filter. No individual can encounter every historical interpretation, master every relevant language, inspect every manuscript, reproduce every argument, or personally verify every testimony. Epistemic dependence is unavoidable. The philosophical issue is therefore not whether authority exists, but how it is organized and what consequences follow from that organization.

Zagzebski's account is useful here because it rejects a simple picture in which epistemic autonomy requires refusing authority. We routinely and rationally rely on others. Yet once authority is admitted, further questions arise about how authority is recognized, how much deference it warrants, and how it interacts with the believer's own conscientious judgement (Zagzebski 2012). These questions become more difficult when authority is embedded not in a single expert relationship but in an institution spanning generations.

The relevant unit of analysis is therefore not merely the believer or even the believer-expert pair. It is the **network of epistemic dependence** through which religious knowledge is made available.

3. Sacred sovereignty and epistemic distribution are different axes

The macro comparison motivating this paper uses **monotheistic** and **polytheistic** as structural terms, not as a count of supernatural characters. That distinction needs to be explicit because otherwise the analysis can be derailed by cases in which a tradition contains many divine persons, angels, saints, spirits, or subordinate beings while still locating final sacred authority in one source, or by polytheistic systems in which one deity clearly outranks others.

The operative question is:

Where does legitimate sacred authority ultimately terminate?

A simple way to picture the distinction is to think of a river system. The present classification is concerned first with the **springhead**, not with the complexity of the channels downstream. Does the water ultimately emerge from one recognized source, or from several sources that possess standing in their own right? A single spring can feed a vast and highly branched river system; several springs can also flow into channels that later become tightly controlled or centralized. The number of downstream branches therefore does not by itself tell us how many headwaters the system recognizes.

The analogy is deliberately limited. Sacred authority is not literally hydraulic, and religious traditions are not engineered drainage systems. Its purpose is simply to distinguish **origin** from **distribution**. A monotheistic system may contain many downstream interpreters, intermediaries, offices, and institutions while still tracing legitimate sacred authority back to one ultimate source. A polytheistic system may be hierarchical and coordinated while still recognizing several divine authorities whose standing is not merely delegated from a single apex.

This paper therefore separates **sacred sovereignty** from **epistemic distribution**.

Sacred sovereignty identifies the claimed source or sources of final divine authority. **Epistemic distribution** identifies the human pathways through which that authority is interpreted, transmitted, contested, and applied.

The first axis concerns the top of the religious architecture. The second concerns what happens below it.

3.1 What counts as monotheistic here

For this paper, a religious architecture is **monotheistic** when all legitimate sacred authority is ultimately grounded in a single divine source. Internal differentiation does not by itself defeat that classification.

Classical Trinitarian Christianity is therefore monotheistic for the purposes of this model. Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are not treated in orthodox Trinitarian doctrine as three independent gods with competing ultimate jurisdictions; they are confessed as one God. Likewise, angels, saints, prophets, clergy, councils, and other intermediaries may exercise substantial practical or interpretive authority without becoming independent sources of ultimate sacred sovereignty.

The same point applies more generally. A system may have many layers, offices, messengers, and interpretive institutions while remaining centralized at the level of sacred sovereignty if every legitimate branch must finally reconcile itself to one supreme source.

The Hebrew Bible makes the exclusivist tendency especially visible in commands such as “You shall have no other gods before me” and associated prohibitions on rival worship (Exodus 20:3-5; Deuteronomy 5:7-9). The numbering and theological interpretation of particular commandments differ across Jewish and Christian traditions, so the present argument does not depend on counting commandments. What matters structurally is the claim of **exclusive ultimate sovereignty**.

This definition is synchronic rather than essentialist. Judaism, Christianity, and other traditions have changed across long histories, and ancient Israelite religion itself developed through periods that scholars describe in different ways. The framework classifies a religious configuration by the authority structure it instantiates at the time under examination, not by treating a modern label as timeless.

3.2 What counts as polytheistic here

For this paper, a religious architecture is **polytheistic** when multiple divine authorities possess standing that is not merely reducible to delegation from one exclusive sovereign source.

This does not require equality among gods.

A polytheistic system may be strongly hierarchical. One deity may be king, first in rank, politically dominant, or unusually powerful. **Supremacy is not the same thing as monopoly**. Hierarchy remains compatible with distributed sacred sovereignty when other gods retain legitimate domains, cults, powers, or jurisdictions that are not simply temporary offices bestowed by the highest-ranking god.

Greek religion provides a useful illustration. Zeus can occupy a position of extraordinary primacy without thereby turning Poseidon, Hades, Athena, Apollo, or other gods into mere subordinate functionaries whose divine legitimacy derives only from Zeus. The Olympian order is hierarchical, but it remains plural: different gods possess distinct spheres of concern and receive legitimate worship without worship of one automatically negating the others. This is one reason “Zeus was king” does not collapse Greek polytheism into the same architecture as exclusive monotheism (Burkert 1985; Parker 2005).

The distinction can therefore be stated compactly:

Plurality inside a hierarchy does not establish distributed sovereignty; hierarchy inside a plurality does not establish centralized sovereignty.

The relevant issue is whether multiple sacred authorities possess **irreducible standing**.

3.3 A two-axis model

Separating the two axes prevents several category errors.

A monotheistic tradition can have a **distributed epistemic architecture**. It may affirm one God while allowing extensive disagreement among schools, scholars, local communities, or interpretive traditions.

A polytheistic tradition can have a **concentrated epistemic architecture**. Multiple gods may be recognized while priesthoods, political institutions, ritual authorities, or canonical practices centralize human interpretation and enforcement.

The resulting possibilities are therefore:

Sacred sovereignty	Human epistemic distribution	Structural possibility
Singular / exclusive	Concentrated	One ultimate divine source with narrow authoritative interpretation
Singular / exclusive	Distributed	One ultimate divine source with multiple legitimate interpretive pathways
Plural / irreducible	Concentrated	Multiple divine authorities with centralized human mediation
Plural / irreducible	Distributed	Multiple divine authorities with multiple semi-independent interpretive pathways

This distinction also clarifies the relationship between the present paper and the macro companion. The macro comparison concerns broad religious architectures of sovereignty, canon, variation, and coordination. The present paper isolates the **downstream epistemic axis** and asks what happens after claims of sacred authority enter human systems.

The metaphysical structure tells us where authority is said to originate. The epistemic architecture tells us how fallible humans move that authority through the world.

4. Two ideal-type authority patterns

With the source-level distinction now fixed, the downstream network can be analyzed on its own terms. This paper distinguishes two ideal-type epistemic mechanisms: **concentrated epistemic authority** and **distributed epistemic authority**.

These mechanisms describe how human communities stabilize and contest religious knowledge. They should not be inferred mechanically from the number of gods, divine persons, intermediaries, or institutions present in a tradition. Sacred sovereignty and human epistemic distribution interact, but they are not the same variable.

The distinction below is therefore functional.

4.1 Concentrated epistemic authority

An epistemic system is relatively concentrated when a small number of recognized nodes have unusually high power to stabilize contested belief. Those nodes might be a central institution, a canonical text interpreted under privileged rules, a council, a scholarly hierarchy, an office, or another locus with wide authority.

Concentration offers clear advantages.

It can lower the cost of coordination. Members need not independently reconstruct the whole tradition whenever a dispute arises. Shared authoritative reference points allow large communities to preserve identity across time and geography. Concentration can also protect a tradition against rapid fragmentation. When interpretive disputes proliferate, a recognized mechanism for settling them can sustain common practice and language.

Concentration may also preserve accumulated expertise. Some religious questions genuinely depend on specialized linguistic, historical, legal, or theological knowledge. A system that recognizes expertise can prevent every dispute from being flattened into a contest of equally weighted personal opinions.

The risk appears when the same machinery that makes authority efficient also makes error efficient.

If a highly authoritative node adopts a mistaken interpretation, the system may propagate that interpretation widely before competing assessments can develop. If the node also controls the mechanisms by which its own authority is reviewed, correction becomes structurally expensive. The problem is not merely that an authority can be wrong. Every person and institution can be wrong. The problem is **error amplification**: the degree to which being wrong in one place produces synchronized error elsewhere.

A concentrated system can therefore have high coherence and low redundancy. In engineering language, a single point of failure is efficient until it fails. In epistemic language, the worry is not computational reliability but whether enough independent judgement survives for the community to recognize that a trusted authority has erred.

4.2 Distributed epistemic authority

An epistemic system is relatively distributed when interpretive authority is spread across multiple semi-independent nodes: local communities, schools, scholars, traditions, specialists, practices, or individual interpreters whose standing is not wholly derived from one central authority.

Distribution also offers real advantages.

It creates epistemic redundancy. Different communities can preserve different readings, notice different tensions, and develop alternative responses to new circumstances. Local knowledge can remain locally available instead of being forced immediately into a universal rule. Errors may remain contained rather than propagating throughout the system. Dissent can survive long enough to accumulate arguments and evidence.

Distribution may also reduce the problem of authority capture. If no single institution can settle every dispute, a mistaken or self-protective authority has fewer means to erase competing judgement entirely.

But distribution has its own costs.

A community may become unable to distinguish productive pluralism from simple fragmentation. Interpretations can multiply without an agreed procedure for comparison. Local errors can persist indefinitely because no sufficiently trusted mechanism exists to resolve them. Members may select authorities

opportunistically, moving toward whichever interpreter confirms an antecedent preference. Shared language can weaken until different subcommunities retain the same label for a tradition while no longer sharing enough epistemic structure to communicate effectively.

Distributed systems therefore tend to trade lower error-amplification risk for higher **convergence cost**: the difficulty of bringing disagreement back into enough common structure for coordinated belief and practice.

The contrast can be summarized as follows:

Dimension	More concentrated authority	More distributed authority
Coordination	Faster, lower cost	Slower, negotiation-heavy
Continuity	Strong common reference points	Multiple local continuities
Error propagation	Potentially system-wide	More often locally contained
Correction	Efficient if authority self-corrects; difficult if it does not	Multiple correction routes; weak convergence
Dissent	Easier to resolve or exclude	Easier to preserve
Expertise	Can be strongly institutionalized	Can be diverse but uneven
Fragmentation risk	Lower	Higher
Authority capture risk	Higher if central nodes fail	Lower centrally, but local capture remains possible

The point is not that one column is epistemically virtuous and the other defective. Each protects against a failure mode produced by the other.

5. The correction problem

The deepest issue is therefore not simply authority versus autonomy. It is **correction**.

A religious tradition is temporally extended. It inherits claims from people who are dead, interprets texts produced under conditions no longer recoverable in full, encounters new moral and scientific knowledge, experiences internal disputes, and must decide whether later developments preserve, distort, or legitimately extend earlier commitments. Even a tradition committed to an infallible divine source must rely on fallible human agents to recognize, transmit, interpret, translate, teach, and apply that source.

This creates a structural problem:

How can a community preserve enough continuity to remain the same tradition while preserving enough independent judgement to recognize when its inherited interpretation is wrong?

Too little continuity and correction becomes indistinguishable from replacement. Too little corrigibility and continuity becomes indistinguishable from entrenchment.

This problem is visible in discussions of tradition itself. Wynn’s account emphasizes that tradition requires creative judgement in distinguishing genuinely revelatory content from historically local assumptions (Wynn 2017). That judgement cannot be performed without some authority structure, because somebody must be entitled to interpret the relation between inherited deposit and current circumstances. Yet if the structure treats every inherited judgement as self-validating, the distinction Wynn describes becomes impossible in practice.

Kojonen’s comparison between pre-emptive authority and the expert-as-advisor model illustrates the same tension in a more specific setting. On a pre-emptive view, recognized authority can replace some of the believer’s first-order reasoning; on an advisory view, authority guides judgement while leaving more room for correction and disagreement (Kojonen 2024). The present model does not require choosing one of those accounts globally. Instead, it asks where and when a tradition permits each relation.

A community may treat some questions as settled by pre-emptive authority, others as open to expert guidance, and still others as matters of individual conscience. It may allow local variation in ritual but not doctrine, or scholarly disagreement in interpretation but not public teaching. The architecture is therefore multi-layered.

This suggests that the epistemic health of a religious tradition depends partly on whether its layers are **differentiated**. If every disagreement is escalated to the highest authority, local judgement atrophies and the centre becomes overloaded. If no disagreement can ever be escalated, persistent contradictions may fracture the community. A robust architecture requires some method for deciding which questions need common settlement and which can remain plural.

The same is true of memory. Correction is impossible if a system retains only final decisions and discards the arguments that lost. A future community may need precisely the evidence or distinction that a prior majority rejected. Preserving dissent does not make dissent true. It preserves the possibility that later evidence can reopen a question without reconstructing the entire dispute from fragments.

This gives us a second thesis:

Epistemic corrigibility requires not merely permission to disagree, but durable access to alternative interpretations, reasons for past decisions, and routes by which settled authority can be reconsidered.

A tradition can therefore appear pluralistic in the present while remaining structurally incorrigible if dissent has no memory, no standing, or no path back into authoritative consideration.

6. Bounded pluralism

The trade-off between concentration and distribution suggests a middle architecture, which I call **bounded pluralism**.

Bounded pluralism is not a theological doctrine and does not imply that all religious claims are equally true. It is an epistemic design principle: preserve multiple sites of competent judgement inside a shared framework strong enough to sustain mutual intelligibility.

The “bounded” component matters. Unlimited interpretive proliferation can destroy the common reference points that make disagreement meaningful. If two groups no longer share texts, standards, vocabulary, practices, or criteria of relevance, their apparent disagreement may become equivocation between different traditions.

The “pluralism” component matters equally. If only one route of interpretation remains legitimate, the system gains coherence at the cost of epistemic redundancy. Correction then depends heavily on the reliability and self-correcting capacity of that route.

A bounded-pluralist architecture would exhibit at least five features.

6.1 Shared but non-exhaustive reference points

A tradition requires enough common material for disagreement to have an object. This may include canonical texts, central narratives, ritual commitments, historical memories, or high-level normative principles. But shared reference points need not settle every downstream interpretation.

The important distinction is between **orientation** and **exhaustive determination**. A canon can orient inquiry without containing a mechanically unique answer to every question. A tradition can preserve identity while acknowledging that interpretation remains active.

6.2 Multiple legitimate interpretive sites

A robust system should not make all epistemic competence derivative from one node. Different kinds of questions may require different kinds of expertise. Linguistic analysis, historical context, lived practice, local knowledge, moral reasoning, and systematic theology need not be collapsed into a single authority.

This does not imply equal authority. Epistemic pluralism is compatible with hierarchy. The point is that hierarchy should not erase the possibility that different kinds of competence can generate legitimate friction.

6.3 Preserved dissent

A dissenting view should be distinguishable from a forgotten view.

Preservation can take many forms: archived arguments, minority reports, recorded objections, competing commentaries, or institutional memory that retains the reasons a question was controversial. The epistemic function is the same. The community preserves evidence about its own uncertainty.

This is especially important across generations. A later community may possess evidence unavailable to the earlier one. If the earlier dispute has been compressed into “question resolved,” the later community inherits a conclusion without the epistemic landscape from which it emerged.

6.4 Review without permanent instability

If every decision can be reopened at any moment for any reason, common practice becomes impossible. But if no decision can be reopened, correction becomes impossible.

Bounded pluralism therefore requires **thresholds for review**. New evidence, newly relevant expertise, changed circumstances, serious internal contradiction, or persistent disagreement may justify reopening a settled question. The exact threshold will vary by tradition. The philosophical point is that a route must exist.

6.5 Authority that is strong without being self-validating

The strongest form of epistemic capture occurs when an authority’s claim to reliability can be assessed only by standards that the same authority controls. Any challenge can then be reclassified as evidence of the challenger’s unreliability.

No complex tradition can eliminate circularity entirely. People learn who to trust partly from other trusted people. But degrees matter. Independent archives, multiple interpretive institutions, preserved minority traditions, and distinct forms of expertise can provide partial external checks even when no perfectly neutral standpoint exists.

Bounded pluralism therefore aims not at authority-free religion, but at **authority with redundancy**.

7. Religious disagreement revisited

This architectural perspective changes how we should understand religious disagreement.

The standard disagreement case asks how A should update after learning that B disagrees. But A's judgement about B's competence is itself partly inherited from an epistemic architecture. A may have been taught that members of another tradition lack crucial spiritual insight, that a certain institutional office has privileged interpretive authority, that a particular text overrides testimony, or that personal religious experience should be treated as private but decisive evidence. B may inherit an entirely different ranking.

Pittard notes that strong conciliationism becomes difficult in religious contexts partly because the qualifications needed to identify relevant peers are themselves entangled with the dispute (Pittard 2021). The architectural model pushes that problem one step further: traditions do not merely disagree about conclusions; they may disagree about the **structure by which epistemic standing is assigned**.

This creates what might be called **second-order architectural disagreement**.

Two believers may agree on the first-order evidence yet disagree about who is authorized to interpret it. Or they may agree that expertise matters but disagree about what counts as expertise. They may agree on the importance of tradition but disagree about whether tradition can override an individual reading of scripture. They may agree that revelation is authoritative but disagree about which institutional mechanisms reliably transmit it.

These disagreements cannot be solved simply by adding more first-order evidence because the parties are using different rules for weighting that evidence.

This does not make rational dialogue impossible. It does mean that disagreement analysis should sometimes move from propositions to **epistemic roles**. Instead of asking only "Why do you believe (p)?" we may need to ask:

*Why does this source receive authority? What would count as a defeater for that authority? Who may identify such a defeater? How is dissent preserved? What makes an interpreter competent? What happens when two recognized authorities conflict? * Which judgements are revisable, and by what process?*

These are philosophical questions about religious knowledge even when no immediate truth claim is being adjudicated.

They also help explain why merely increasing diversity of viewpoints does not automatically improve a community's epistemic position. A system can contain many voices while routing all authoritative decisions through one gate. Conversely, a system can appear institutionally centralized while preserving significant independent scholarly or local judgement beneath the formal surface.

The number of speakers is not the same thing as the distribution of authority.

8. Objections and limits

Objection 1: Truth matters, not architecture

One might object that a false decentralized system remains false, while a true centralized authority may transmit truth efficiently. Why care about architecture rather than simply asking which religion is correct?

The objection is right about the priority of truth but wrong about the irrelevance of structure.

Architecture is not a substitute for truth. It concerns the conditions under which fallible humans can acquire, preserve, and correct beliefs about truth. Even if a religious tradition begins from a true revelation, members still face questions of interpretation, transmission, application, and disagreement. Unless human intermediaries are also infallible, the structure through which their judgements travel remains epistemically relevant.

The argument is therefore conditional: **given human fallibility, authority distribution affects the cost and recoverability of error.**

Objection 2: The model romanticizes decentralization

Distributed systems can generate misinformation, charismatic local authority, factionalism, sectarian isolation, and endless interpretive drift. Why assume more voices improve correction?

They do not necessarily.

This paper explicitly rejects the claim that maximal decentralization is epistemically optimal. Distributed authority lowers some risks while increasing others. Bounded pluralism is proposed precisely because plurality without shared structure can collapse into fragmentation. Redundancy is useful only if competing interpretations remain mutually legible and if some mechanisms exist for comparison.

The aim is not “more voices” in the abstract. It is enough independent judgement to make authoritative error detectable without making common judgement impossible.

Objection 3: Religious authority is divine, not institutional

A believer may respond that the highest religious authority is God. Human institutions are therefore secondary and should not be treated as the source of religious knowledge.

Nothing in the argument requires denying divine authority.

The distinction is between the **source of truth** and the **human architecture of access to that source**. If God reveals truth, humans still confront questions about which event, text, tradition, experience, or testimony genuinely carries revelation; how it should be interpreted; and how conflicting claims should be resolved. The philosophical problem begins at the point where fallible people must recognize and transmit putatively infallible authority.

Indeed, stronger claims of divine authority can make the human architecture more important, not less, because misidentifying a human interpretation as divinely guaranteed raises the cost of correction.

Objection 4: The concentrated/distributed distinction is too coarse

Real religions are historically complex, internally diverse, and institutionally hybrid. Any two-column model risks distortion.

Agreed.

The distinction is intentionally an ideal-type instrument, not a taxonomy of religions. It is useful only if applied to specific mechanisms. A single tradition may centralize canon, distribute local practice, centralize ordination, distribute scholarship, and permit wide private interpretation. The correct unit of analysis is therefore not “Christianity is centralized” or “polytheism is distributed,” but “this function in this tradition allocates authority in this way.”

The earlier macro comparison that motivates this companion can still be useful as a high-level map, but the present paper deliberately moves down one level of granularity. Its purpose is partly corrective: broad religious categories should not be allowed to substitute for mechanism-level analysis.

Objection 5: Preserving dissent gives error too much status

If every rejected view is preserved, communities may grant pseudo-legitimacy to claims that were decisively refuted.

Preservation is not endorsement.

Archives preserve false claims because future understanding depends on knowing what was considered and why it failed. A minority report need not receive equal doctrinal status to remain epistemically useful. The relevant distinction is between **settled for practice** and **erased from memory**.

A tradition can act on a conclusion while retaining enough of the discarded path to make future reassessment possible.

9. Implications for philosophy of religion

The architectural perspective suggests several shifts in emphasis.

First, religious disagreement should sometimes be treated as a problem of **institutional epistemology**, not merely interpersonal rationality. Before asking how a believer should respond to a peer, we should ask how the believer's tradition constructs categories such as peer, expert, authority, heretic, teacher, witness, or interpreter.

Second, religious pluralism has an internal as well as external form. Philosophers often discuss plurality between religions. Equally important is how a tradition handles plurality **within** itself. A community that can sustain principled internal disagreement may respond differently to external disagreement from one that requires strong internal convergence.

Third, continuity and correction should be treated as jointly necessary epistemic goods. Philosophical accounts often emphasize either fidelity to revelation and tradition or autonomy and critical judgement. An architectural view asks how a system can preserve both without pretending the tension disappears.

Fourth, the unit of comparison between religious traditions should sometimes be **mechanisms rather than labels**. Canonical authority, testimonial authority, expert advice, communal discernment, individual experience, institutional review, and preserved dissent can be compared across traditions without assuming that all monotheisms or polytheisms instantiate the same pattern.

This mechanism-level approach also provides a bridge between philosophy of religion and social epistemology. Contemporary social epistemology already studies expertise, testimony, group belief, trust, epistemic authority, and institutional knowledge. Religious traditions are unusually rich cases because they are long-lived, textually and ritually mediated, normatively serious, and often explicit about authority. They therefore provide not merely applications of general epistemology but test environments in which the relation between authority and autonomy is unusually visible.

Finally, the framework encourages a different question about epistemic humility.

Humility is often treated as an individual virtue: a person should recognize their fallibility. But institutions can also be more or less structurally humble. A system displays structural humility when it retains ways for future participants to discover where present authorities may be wrong. This does not require weak conviction. It requires refusing to make correction logically or institutionally impossible.

That may be the most important distinction in the paper:

A tradition can hold beliefs strongly while still preserving the machinery by which those beliefs could be corrected.

Conviction and corrigibility are not opposites unless the architecture makes them so.

10. Relation to the macro structural model

The companion paper *Architectural Legacies* compares polytheistic and monotheistic systems at a high level, treating them as idealized architectures for sacred authority, canon, variation, adaptation, and scope. Its purpose is macro-comparative. It asks what broad structural patterns become visible when religious systems are viewed as organizational responses to recurring coordination problems.

The present paper narrows the claim by separating two layers that the macro view can easily blur: **where sacred sovereignty is claimed to terminate and how human epistemic authority is distributed beneath that source structure.**

It does **not** argue that polytheism entails distributed epistemic authority or that monotheism entails concentrated epistemic authority. A monotheistic architecture can contain wide downstream interpretive pluralism; a polytheistic architecture can contain centralized human institutions. Instead, the present paper extracts the epistemic-distribution axis and treats it independently. This produces a more precise hypothesis:

Religious traditions vary in how they distribute epistemic authority beneath their claims about ultimate sacred sovereignty, and that distribution affects their characteristic modes of continuity, disagreement, error propagation, and correction.

The advantage of separating the two papers is methodological. The macro model can remain useful as a comparative map without carrying the full argumentative burden of a theory of religious knowledge. The present paper can then stress-test one part of that map at finer resolution.

If the focused analysis reveals that authority distribution cuts across the polytheism-monotheism distinction, that is not a failure of the macro project. It is exactly the kind of refinement a multi-scale approach should produce. Broad categories identify candidate patterns; mechanism-level analysis determines which patterns survive closer inspection.

11. Conclusion

Religious epistemology does not occur only inside individual minds. Religious belief is transmitted through communities that preserve texts, assign authority, recognize experts, remember disputes, teach interpretive practices, and decide which disagreements deserve continued standing.

Those arrangements form an epistemic architecture.

Concentrated authority can preserve coherence, continuity, and common reference points, but it increases the danger that authoritative error will propagate widely and become difficult to challenge. Distributed

authority can preserve local knowledge, independent judgement, and multiple correction routes, but it increases fragmentation and the cost of convergence. Neither model is sufficient by itself.

The more promising target is bounded pluralism: shared structure without exhaustive centralization, multiple legitimate interpretive sites without unlimited fragmentation, preserved dissent without equal endorsement, and review mechanisms that permit correction without making every commitment permanently provisional.

This proposal does not tell us which religious claims are true. It does something more limited: it identifies a structural condition under which truth-seeking communities may remain capable of learning from their own fallibility.

A religious tradition need not choose between continuity and correction. But if it wishes to preserve both, it must preserve not only answers, but the epistemic pathways by which answers can still be questioned.

References

- Burkert, Walter. 1985. *Greek Religion: Archaic and Classical*. Translated by John Raffan. Harvard University Press.
- Benton, Matthew A. 2021. "Disagreement and Religion: Problems and Prospects." In *Religious Disagreement and Pluralism*, edited by Matthew A. Benton and Jonathan L. Kvanvig, 1-40. Oxford University Press. <https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780198849865.003.0001>
- Benton, Matthew A., and Jonathan L. Kvanvig, eds. 2021. *Religious Disagreement and Pluralism*. Oxford University Press. <https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780198849865.001.0001>
- Christensen, David. 2007. "Epistemology of Disagreement: The Good News." *The Philosophical Review* 116: 187-217.
- Feldman, Richard. 2007. "Reasonable Religious Disagreements." In *Philosophers without Gods: Meditations on Atheism and the Secular Life*, edited by Louise M. Antony. Oxford University Press.
- Kojonen, E. V. R. 2024. "On Sola Scriptura and Social Epistemology." *Studia Theologica - Nordic Journal of Theology* 78 (2): 162-179. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0039338X.2024.2420227>
- Paterson, Anthony. 2025. *Architectural Legacies: A Structural Comparison of Polytheistic and Monotheistic Systems and Their Continuing Influence on Modern Institutions*. Fractal Media Infrastructure. Public conceptual paper.
- Parker, Robert. 2005. *Polytheism and Society at Athens*. Oxford University Press.
- Pittard, John. 2021. "Rationalist Resistance to Disagreement-Motivated Religious Skepticism." In *Religious Disagreement and Pluralism*, edited by Matthew A. Benton and Jonathan L. Kvanvig, 180-216. Oxford University Press. <https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780198849865.003.0008>
- Wynn, Mark. 2017. "Tradition." In *The Oxford Handbook of the Epistemology of Theology*, edited by William J. Abraham and Frederick D. Aquino, 126-140. Oxford University Press. <https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780199662241.013.36>
- Zagzebski, Linda Trinkaus. 2012. *Epistemic Authority: A Theory of Trust, Authority, and Autonomy in Belief*. Oxford University Press. <https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780199936472.001.0001>